Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on John Donne's "The Triple Foole"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the relationship—as the speaker presents it—between being in love and writing about being in love and, additionally, having the unpublished expression of being in love published in John Donne's "The Triple Foole" include

analogy,
anthropomorphism,
connotation,
couplet,
denotation,
elision (syncope),
iambic (not alone pentameter),
imagery,
irony,
inversion,
metaphor,
meter,
onomatopoeia,
paradox,
personification,
plagiarism,
rhyme,
rhythm,
sigmatism,
speaker / persona,
synonym, and
truncation.

The young writer should pick up on the several terms used in the speaker's assessment of the role poetry takes in the making of this particular "love's fool": *Rimes* (line 9), *numbers* (line 10), *verse* (both lines 11 and 17), *songs* (line 19), and in doing so, call attention to the speaker-as-poet's searching for the right words to express his pain and grief. The varying aspects of versification associated with the writing of poetry: the measured meter (numbers), the rhyming (rime), and the finding of the right words, their connotations and denotation, to carry the lyrics (song), might be recognized as the very elements that critics agree complement one another in Donne's poetry.

The focus of the response should follow the stages that begin with having fallen in love (the first fool) and finally end with having that expression of love, the writing of poetry, published for both the world to see and for others to "voice" (line 13), thus ensuring the speaker's having to revisit (as the third fool) the pain and grief that engendered the writing of the poem in the first place. The middle stage (the second fool) is founded on the expectation that the writing of poetry should relieve the pain: "if I could draw my paines, / Through Rimes vexation, I should them allay [. . .]" (lines 8-9).

Line 13's "Some man, his art and voice to show, / Doth Set and sing my paine" might be reckoned as plagiarism, which the *Handbook* reminds us, has been viewed differently across time in our culture.

All in all, there should appear some understanding of the speaker's chronicling of the incremental foolishness—the three fools, the three stagings. An insightful comment regarding the irony that prevails in the speaker's writing something that both offers a confession of his foolishness and, through the intended or unintended sharing of which, brings delight to others (line 15) while renewing his own pain informs the better student response.